

Team 8

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T6 Final Paper

Part 1- Company Access

Somfy Systems is a company that manufactures intelligent motorization and automated control solutions for residential and commercial window coverings. This includes blinds, awnings, curtains, shutters, and the tools needed to control them. Somfy Systems has strengthened its market positioning by executing user friendly smart technology that enhances security, comfort, and efficiency.

Our team specifically examined the Sales and Distribution department of Somfy Systems. It is located in Dayton, New Jersey where we were able to get online interviews with a manager, Jim Ruh, and warehouse employee, Kevin Carullo, to get both perspectives of the output problem. The Sales and Distribution Department consists of sales representatives, warehouse workers, logistics workers, and managers to coordinate product flow and customer relationships within this location of Somfy Systems.

Part 2- Background Information

Somfy Systems emphasizes innovation, comfort, and efficiency, which is presented in their mission statement “improve living environments through sustainable motorization, creating better living for all.” Within the Sales and Distribution department, the primary focus is to ensure products are shipped and sold in an effective and efficient manner. With this strategic focus, the sixty Somfy System locations worldwide have created a strong international business presence.

Somfy Systems is in the competitive building automation industry, with its main competitors being Lutron, Doota and JieCang. Lutron provides premium building automation while Dooya focuses on lower cost products, Somfy is able to differentiate themselves by providing reliable good quality products for reasonable prices. The building automation industry

continues to expand significantly due to the growing desire to be efficient, technology-based, and sustainable. The industry was valued at USD 94.5 billion in 2026 and a projected value of USD 184.42 billion by 2034 (Fortune Business Insights, 2026). Somfy Systems will continue to grow as it is positioned in a rapidly evolving market.

The organizational structure of the Sales and Distribution Department consists of 40 employees divided into three sections: inside sales, outside sales, and specification. The average age for these workers is 42 and average tenure is 13 years. The sales group at Somfy Systems is also made up of 80% males and 20% women. While these are the statistics for the New Jersey Somfy Systems location, the organization has 200 workers in North America and 10,000 employees worldwide.

One beneficial practice in the Sales and Distribution Department is maintaining workers for a long period of time. Experienced long-term workers tend to support consistent performance, relationship building, and overall better communication. While the organization continues to expand, maintaining strong communication and engagement are both necessary for the success of the company.

Part 3- Data Collection Methods

Our team gathered in our project group chat to discuss which company to interview and study for the assignment on Monday, February 16th. The organization that we chose is Somfy Systems. We created questions for the interview with our primary contact Jim Ruh, and also prepared for the analysis. Once the first interview was completed, we conducted research on the industry, management styles, and other companies before preparing for the second interview. The

second interview with a warehouse employee, Kevin Carullo, gave us ample insight into the management and workspace for our analysis.

With the two interviews completed, we were able to analyze our notes, complete secondary research, and begin compiling our ideas, recommendations, and concepts.

Timeline

February 16th- Group Meeting to plan project and choose organization

February 20th- Group meeting to make interview questions for the manager

February 27th- Conduct the first interview with Somfy Systems Manager

February 28th- Zoom group meeting to discuss interview responses and plan out upcoming analysis

March 10th - Create interview questions for the secondary interview

March 27th- Conduct secondary interview of the second level employee, write down interview notes and transcript

April 13th- Group Meeting to delegate tasks and complete secondary research

April 20th- Group Meeting to check progress, completed goals, and recommendations

Part 4- Secondary Research

Building Automation Systems Market Size, Share & Industry Analysis

According to the website by Fortune Insights, the building automation system market is experiencing rapid growth because of the desire for smart technology, efficiency, and sustainability. The emphasis on this growth as they showed the industry valued at USD 94.5 billion in 2026 and a projected value of USD 184.42 billion by 2034, which highlights the significant expansion opportunities for companies like Somfy Systems. Key trends that were

mentioned include: the integration of IoT, cloud-based control systems, and AI-driven technologies. These advancements continue to facilitate the growth of the industry, which is a great circumstance for Somfy Systems.

How global manufacturer Somfy monitors and protects its Active Directory infrastructure

Somfy Systems demonstrates their strong management practices through their global coordination and continuous improvement. They operate across dozens of countries with hundreds of departments by relying on structured management systems to ensure consistency, efficiency, and adaptation to market needs. With the integration of digital tools to get live monitoring, locations and employees are able to take more accountability, and make adjustments for any errors made. Based on this, Somfy Systems reflects a proactive management style that encourages employee and management development, and ongoing evaluation to ensure long-term success and security.

Part 5- Output Problem Statement

After our preliminary research on Somfy Systems, it became evident from the interviews that the company has been struggling with employee engagement. The hybrid work model that emerged from COVID-19 led to reduced interpersonal interaction, making it harder to maintain connections between employees and managers. This has contributed to their decreased employee involvement, ultimately impacting overall performance levels.

Along with their internal difficulties, external factors such as the industry-wide slump of “low demand and high costs,” and ongoing supply chain issues have significantly contributed to their output problem. Kevin Carullo, a warehouse employee, said that during a rough period in

the industry, staying positive becomes more of a challenge than a source of motivation. He goes further to say that some managers notice when people are stressed, but the majority of the time the focus is on “getting the job done, not really how people are feeling.” A volatile industry can shift a company to become more task focused, costing employees to struggle building connections with their managers beyond what is required from their work. Due to the high stakes environment, the managers tend to rely on their own judgement when making decisions, limiting the level of trust between employees and management.

Kevin Carullo expressed a preference for a collaborative workplace. As a result of the struggling sales industry, the majority of choices are made autonomously by managers, even if faced with disagreement. He stated that management appreciates employee input and is usually understanding, but it can be conflicting since they are not working side by side with them and usually “just see numbers and not actual products.” The employees feel disconnected from the execution rather than the approach, which negatively affects their sense of involvement with the company. They view this as an issue influencing output performance, since they feel less involved in the decisions made by the company.

During the interview, it seemed like communication was the focal point. The Shipping Employee highlighted how being virtual can create issues connecting with others in the workplace, but based on his other answers it seems like the main cause is a lack of trust between employees and managers. The Sales Manager said something similar, explaining that communication between departments is sometimes good but other times causes problems depending on how it’s handled. He also said that with more remote work, there’s been less accountability and teamwork, which makes it harder for everyone to stay on the same page.

The relatively new hybrid work environment has contributed to reduced interpersonal interaction and communication, which hinders their trust and alignment with the company. In the sales market, managers have to act quickly and make firm decisions because the stakes are high. Because of this, they may focus more on results and getting things done rather than always listening to employee input. This shows how both perspectives connect, and how better communication and more involvement could help improve trust and overall performance. Considering the high pressure environment in this workplace, improving communication between managers and workers can limit stress, and make sure everyone is involved and aware of their contributions.

Part 6- Analysis of Output Problem and Integration with Course Content

After interviewing two employees from Somfy Systems and identifying the output problem, the two concepts that best analyze the problem are Emotional Intelligence and the Goal-Setting Theory.

Emotional Intelligence:

Emotional Intelligence is the ability to recognize, understand, manage, and use emotions with others and in relationships. In management, emotional intelligence is a critical skill needed to foster relationships, create an open space for communication, and a positive work environment.

With the data collected from our Somfy Systems interviews we can tell that emotional intelligence is related to the weak communication and feeling of disconnect from the company when they are hybrid. In Interview #2, the employee we connected with stated “Online work definitely makes it harder to feel connected to my coworkers,” which is a problem that is

important to address. While online communication is less personal and can limit expressions, the bigger problem is how management can strategically apply emotional intelligence to support engagement, understanding, and connections within their team at Somfy Systems. Through the development of motivation, empathy, and social skills, which are three of the core parts of Emotional Intelligence, whether the team is hybrid or in person, employees will feel more connected to the company and their coworkers.

However, from management's perspective, the main responsibility is to ensure tasks are completed and the functions needed to run the business are fulfilled. In our interviews, it was said that “Some managers notice when people are stressed, but a lot of the time the focus is still just on getting the job done, not really how people are feeling, which is understandable when they are trying to run a business.” This is a common challenge in remote work environments, where the focus on efficiency can begin to outweigh the importance of team connection and the relationships that develop as a result.

In a research article, Wigert and White (2022) found that two of the top challenges in online work are “Impaired working relationship with coworkers” and “Feel less connected to organization's culture.” When examining the connection between the interviews and the research article, it becomes evident that emotional intelligence is closely linked to the quality of workplace communication and overall employee engagement. Managers who actively recognize and respond to their employees' emotions generally run a workplace with better communication, coordination, and promote better relationships. Without the intentional use of emotional intelligence, especially in a hybrid work environment, employees are bound to feel disconnected, less engaged, and have weakened relationships with the company and coworkers.

Goal Setting Theory:

The goal setting theory is a helpful tool to understand the problem at Somfy Systems. Goal setting theory states that performance is predicted on how well a person knows what to do and what they should be attempting to achieve. Clearly defined goals allow employees to be more focused on their work, see themselves as more productive, and understand where they fit in. Research supports this idea saying, “a specific high goal leads to even higher performance than urging people to do their best” (Goal Setting Theory by Ye Cui). On the other hand, when the goals are not defined or constantly change, it leads to confusion, lack of motivation, and disconnection from their work for employees.

Our interviews reveal that this is occurring at Somfy. Kevin, the warehouse employee, said that he feels as though “it feels more like we are trying to fix things and deal with issues rather than getting ahead.” This indicates employees are continually reacting to issues rather than working towards a clearly defined goal. When employees are continually reacting rather than addressing goals, it can be frustrating because it appears that they are not making any headway. Additionally, on the management side, it was indicated that “less accountability and less teamwork” were occurring. This could indicate that employees are not sure about their obligation or what their relationship is to other team members’ work.

The lack of clear goals directly causes employees to feel less motivated and more disconnected, particularly employees who are working in hybrid environments. Employees who do not know what success looks like because they lack defined goals are often challenged to remain motivated. Employees may feel as though there is no purpose associated with their work, which then creates a high likelihood of losing interest in their position or connecting with the company's purpose. Hybrid work does create even greater challenges, as employees are not

physically present with their team members and leader, and therefore they will not receive direction and timely feedback in the same manner as they do when they are working in-person.

In addition, not having clear goals can mess up teamwork and communication. If people don't know what they're supposed to be doing, they could end up doing the same work as someone else, or missing tasks they were supposed to do. This can cause confusion and frustration within the team. The research noted that in order for goals to be effective, they should be defined and accompanied by feedback that will enable employees to stay on track and improve their performance. Without this level of clarity, it will be more and more difficult for employees to remain on the same page as well as to work efficiently as a team.

The Goal Setting Theory can explain how some of the employees in Somfy Systems are showing lower levels of motivation and are discussing greater feelings of disconnect. If employees do not have enough structure or direction to complete their work, they may feel like they are only responding to issues instead of making progress towards something meaningful. With less motivation, employees may have more difficulty communicating with others, and as a result, they will feel less connected to their jobs and the business.

Part 7- Recommendations

First Recommendation:

Based on both the interviews and outside research, our first recommendation for solving the identified output problem connected to the Emotional Intelligence concept is to devote more attention to forming connections at an emotional level between the employees and management.

The output problem Somfy Systems is faced with regards performance levels which derives from the lack of employee involvement, which concerns the self-awareness aspect of

emotional intelligence. One approach the organization could use to address this shortcoming is by increasing transparency in the decision-making process by management. Sharing and explaining the criteria used by managers in their decision-making process can allow for a clearer understanding of the criteria behind company choices, and clarify how employees can contribute to that outcome. Greater transparency also opens the environment for employees to feel more comfortable contributing ideas or seeking feedback, ultimately creating a greater sense of involvement in employees. Since increasing transparency will enable communication among multiple departments, increasing attention towards internal activities will help the flow of work, alleviating the issues of involvement felt by employees.

FedEx, one of the largest organizations in the logistics industry has seen recent success by implementing transparency in their internal operations. FedEx created an annual employee survey where employees provided feedback on managers, encouraging open communication. This helped build the trust between employees and managers, since they are expected to understand and respond to their feedback. The survey revealed that individuals' leadership skills improved by 8-11% overall, and “58% of participants showed very large improvements in influence. 72% did so in decision making” (Shannon Brown). FedEx has seen tremendous growth in employees since applying transparency to their organization internally. Another organization that has implemented transparency is Salesforce. Salesforce publicly conducts and shares pay equity audits, in which they have made salary adjustments in the past to correct inequities. The organization has invested millions of dollars to ensure fair compensation practices, committing to accountability and trust within the workplace. Based on the success both of these organizations have seen by increasing transparency, implementing a similar program based on the necessities of Somfy System could be extremely beneficial to the organization.

Although transparency could offer many positives to the organization, it also has potential to not work in their favor. Transparency in the workplace not only requires managers, but also employees to be open in their communication. In a study conducted by Harvard Business Review, they evaluated two organization's everyday communication, and tested whether distrust was higher in organizations where cc-ing colleagues in an email was the norm. After the evaluation, they found that distrust was "significantly higher in the organizations where cc'ing was the norm," and evaluated this practice as signalling distrust, "which reduces their own trust in, and commitment to, the organization" (De Cremer). Encouraging a transparent environment could make employees feel that every movement they make is being watched, which leads to distrust. It can also lead to blaming within the organization, by focusing on the outcomes rather than the reasoning for why it occurred.

Furthermore, transparency comes at the expense of misinterpretation. Increasing the internal visibility of the organization enables everyone to have their own understanding of the information. This can lead to misunderstandings and information being taken out of context, creating unnecessary confusion. If the information is being misinterpreted frequently, it can lead to increased conflict and discussion, ultimately hurting the organization's efficiency.

Along with these potential drawbacks, transparency can unintentionally enable more frustration among employees. Internally facilitating company information encourages employees to offer more input and ideas, but it can inadvertently create unrealistic expectations. Given the importance of each decision made in the sales industry, not every idea is implemented, which can lead to increased frustration if employees feel that their input is not being recognized. Furthermore, employees can offer inaccurate input due to misinterpretation, and not implementing their suggestions could create dissatisfaction and diminished trust.

Second Recommendation:

The second recommendation is to implement biweekly check-ins between employees and managers, complemented with monthly review meetings to ensure goal progress and alignment. This recommendation connects to our second concept of the goal setting theory, and also overlaps with emotional intelligence through increased communication. Facilitating routine meetings allows for both managers and employees to monitor progress, and adjust the course of action if necessary. In both the biweekly and monthly meetings, employees should develop personal goals in alignment with goals provided by management. Enabling employees to create personal goals allows for them to understand the value of their role, and how it contributes to the bigger picture. Additionally, it creates more accountability through progress monitoring, increasing motivation and involvement among employees. Facilitating these meetings will also increase communication among both parties, ultimately increasing employee engagement and performance levels.

Intel is an example of an organization that found success implementing structured goal systems. Intel developed the OKR (Objectives and Key Results) framework, which was made to create measurable and transparent goals across teams. This framework significantly improved employee understanding of company priorities, and research from Harvard Business Review highlighted that OKRs improve employee alignment and performance by clearly linking individual goals to company objectives (Doerr, 2018). Similarly, Google adopted the OKR system to ensure transparency and alignment, allowing employees to clearly see how their individual goals contribute to larger organizational outcomes. They also have frequent check-ins and quarterly goal-setting sessions between teams and employees, encouraging accountability.

Improved employee alignment and accountability boosted their engagement, ultimately benefitting the company's overall performance.

While regular meetings can improve alignment and support progress tracking, it also has potential drawbacks that should be addressed. One reason the recommendation might not work out is because of the pressure and stress that may arise from the meetings. Regular progress reviews could lead to performance pressure, by employees knowing that they will be frequently assessed. This could potentially shift employees' focus to avoiding mistakes rather than learning and improving from these meetings, reinforcing a performance driven mindset. Instead of feeling motivated by goals, employees may start to feel overwhelmed, ultimately reducing satisfaction and engagement.

Another drawback of this recommendation is the time cost associated with regular meetings. Although the meetings are beneficial to the internal flow of work, it can take time away from the actual work needed. Frequent meetings may interrupt focus if the employee feels the need for preparation prior to each check-in. Additionally, if there's no new content necessary for discussion, the meetings could lose value and become redundant, reducing time efficiency.

Lastly, this recommendation could unintentionally create a perception of micromanagement among employees. Routinely reviewing progress could make employees feel that they are being closely monitored, and potentially controlled depending on how the meetings are conducted. This can reduce their sense of autonomy and trust felt within the organization, negatively impacting employee initiative and engagement.

Communication of Findings

One concept we could utilize to implement our recommendations to Somfy Systems management is through Cialdini's principle of consistency. We can effectively communicate that through employees committing to achievable goals, they will be more likely to stay engaged and consistent. Starting off small with commitments like sharing ideas and participating in discussions will gradually lead to increased involvement. Furthermore, allowing for frequent communication can reinforce prior commitments, encouraging consistency over time. By clearly explaining the significance in employee-set goals aligned with company objectives, and how it allows them to monitor progress and understand their contribution to the larger goal, management will be more likely to implement our suggestions.

Another way to successfully communicate our recommendations to the Somfy Systems management team is through social proof. If we can clearly demonstrate how successful companies like FedEx and Google have adopted similar practices, they may be more likely to implement our recommendations. Considering Somfy Systems operates in a high-stakes industry, using common trends and examples such as Google adopting the Intel framework would be beneficial in supporting our claims. Furthermore, using statistical evidence to reinforce our findings, along with the reasoning behind their improvement would be likely to convince Somfy's management team.

Part 8-Bibliography, Endnotes & Appendices

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CONTACT LOG

Group Meeting

1. Date and time of meeting (hours/duration of meeting)

Friday February 20th 3PM-4PM

2. Method/location (e.g., on site, phone, video call, etc.)

In Person and through text messages

3. Participants (both from your team and the organization)

All members of our team participated, along with Jim Ruh our primary contact person

4. Tasks carried out/what was accomplished

Created interview questions, discussed projects and ideas for analysis.

First Meeting- Manager

1. Date and time of meeting (hours/duration of meeting)

Friday February 27th 4PM-5PM

2. Method/location (e.g., on site, phone, video call, etc.)

Over Zoom meeting.

3. Participants (both from your team and the organization)

All members of our team participated, along with Jim Ruh our primary contact person

4. Tasks carried out/what was accomplished

First Interview with Jim Ruh, write down interview notes.

Manager Interview Questions:

1. Identify the organization or the business unit, work group or department within an organization that your team will be working with this semester.

2. Provide the name, email address and/or phone number of the person who is your team's primary contact. It is recommended that your contact be someone in management as opposed to a student worker.
3. How old is the organization? Briefly describe its history.
4. Where is the organization located? (e.g., single or multiple locations, specific address).
5. Describe the strategy, mission and/or vision of the organization, business unit, work group or department.
6. Who is the competition of the organization, business unit, work group or department?
7. How large is the organization? If your team is studying a business unit, work group or department within an organization, how many employees are there?
8. Describe the demographics of the personnel within the organization, business unit, department or work group profile:
 1. Roles or job duties within the organization-
 2. Tenure with the organization, business unit, department or work group
 3. Age*
 4. Gender*
 5. Race or ethnicity*
9. Based on the initial interview with your point of contact, what is the current output problem(s) facing the organization and/or what opportunities are on the horizon?
10. What are the history, causes and/or underlying reasons surrounding the output problem?
11. What are symptoms of the output problem or ways that the output problem can be "seen" in the organization?

12. From the perspective of your contact at the organization, how do managers versus employees in the organization describe the output problem? If these perspectives are different, explain why these differences exist.

Manager interview notes:

- Covid 19 disruptions continue to have an effect on the way the organization is ran(communication, hybrid work)
- There is organizational alignment as all levels(managers and employees) recognize the same core issues

Group Meeting

- 1.Date and time of meeting (hours/duration of meeting)

Saturday February 28th 12PM-1PM

2. Method/location (e.g., on site, phone, video call, etc.)

Over Zoom meeting.

3. Participants (both from your team and the organization)

All members of our team participated.

4. Tasks carried out/what was accomplished

Discuss interview responses and plan out upcoming analysis

Second Meeting- Warehouse Employee

1. Date and time of meeting (hours/duration of meeting)

Friday March 27th 3PM-5PM

2. Method/location (e.g., on site, phone, video call, etc.)

Facetime

3. Participants (both from your team and the organization)

All members of our team participated, along with Kevin Carullo

4. Tasks carried out/what was accomplished

Secondary interview of the second level employee, write down interview notes and transcript.

Warehouse Employee Interview Questions

1. As an employee, do you feel motivated when coming to work? Why or why not?
2. Since COVID and the switch to remote work, do you feel less loyal to remaining with the company?
3. When working on-site versus hybrid, do you feel as connected to the company and your coworkers?
4. How do company issues like backorders and supply chain disruptions affect your daily work and stress levels?
5. Do you feel comfortable and confident that managers will listen to your concerns or frustrations?
6. What do you think management should do to improve employee motivation and reduce stress related to business issues?
7. Can you recall a time when a manager showed empathy or understanding during a challenging work situation?

8. How well do you think managers recognize and respond to employees' emotions or reactions during difficult situations, such as supply chain delays or customer complaints?

Warehouse employee interview notes:

- Employee motivation is inconsistent because of external business conditions
- Hybrid and remote work reduce interpersonal connection and communication quality
- While some managers show empathy there is a clear prioritization of getting the work done

ENDNOTES

- Employee engagement is highly influenced by communication quality, especially in hybrid work environments, where less face-to-face interaction can weaken team cohesion, relationships and alignment.
- Emotional Intelligence plays a big role in leadership as managers who promote empathy, communication, and understanding can easily improve morale, engagement, and cohesion.
- Goal-Setting Theory suggests that unclear or inconsistent goals contribute to lower motivation and productivity.
- Hybrid work environments have been shown to reduce employee connection and engagement, which aligns with the interview findings from Somfy employees.
- Increased and regularly structured communication can improve alignment and accountability.

